Although most of the concessions were of a futuristic nature, they were specific enough to give the Akali's reasonable grounds to withdraw the agitation without losing face.

The meeting was over by 5 p.m. and the statement was informally shown to a representative of the Akali Dal delegation, who approved it. Satisfied at the cabinet committee's favourable view of their demands, Badal, Talwandi, Tohra and Balwant Singh returned to Amritsar on the evening of 3 November.

Around 6 p.m., G.S. Chawla, senior correspondent of the *Indian Express* , visited Special Secretary (home) P.P. Nayyar in his room. Nayyar was dictating a letter from the home minister to the speaker, informing him that he would like to make the enclosed statement in parliament the next morning. Nayyar told his personal assistant to take that letter with the earlier approved statement as its enclosure to the home minister for his signature, and after that deliver it to the speaker. A copy of the letter with the enclosure was also sent to the prime minister. On Chawla's request, Nayyar allowed him to publish a story on this development, provided he sought approval from a member of the cabinet sub-committee. Instead, G.S Chawla spoke to Swaran Singh and sought his clearance for publishing the report. Nayyar told Chawla to go ahead with his report, which appeared as a front-page lead story in the *Indian Express* on 4 November 1982. [15]

On 4 November, senior Akali leaders were sitting at the SGPC office at Amritsar to announce their next programme. Those who had participated in the talks in Delhi were hopeful that the statement in parliament would enable them to announce the withdrawal of their morcha. Around 10 a.m., Swaran Singh received a call from Amritsar (from either Badal or Balwant Singh) telling him that they were awaiting receipt of the statement shown to them the previous day in New Delhi. Swaran Singh called Pranab Mukherjee, who told Singh that a copy of the statement would be delivered to the Akalis at Amritsar soon after the home minister had made the statement in parliament.

After a couple of hours, the same caller from Amritsar told Swaran Singh that the letter from Delhi had been received, but it had been significantly altered both in 'tone and content'. The caller